



Cloudy, windy 57/45 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 60/41 18

Democracy Dies in Darkness

FRIDAY, MARCH 13, 2026 • \$4

AI money is already affecting midterms

Candidates backed by Big Tech funds have seen success at the polls

BY DAN MERICA AND CLARA ENCE MORSE

Money from artificial intelligence companies is flooding into the 2026 midterms.

AI giants such as OpenAI and Anthropic have already collectively contributed over \$185 million to contests around the country as tech leaders work to influence how, and how much, AI will be regulated, with Democrats and Republicans preparing for an onslaught of campaign spending that could remake key elections.

Candidates backed by AI companies have found early success — of the 20 candidates in the Texas and North Carolina primaries who received AI funds, including many in competitive, open primaries, only one lost her race.

“There is an extreme takeover being attempted ... by people that know they are on the wrong side both of popular opinion and of history and are trying at the last second to get their way by drowning out elections with money,” said New York state Rep. Alex Borens (D), whose campaign for Congress has been both supported and attacked by groups funded by AI interests.

The public is increasingly skeptical of artificial intelligence and the proliferation of data centers needed to power it. A Pew Research Center survey released last year found that 50 percent of Americans were more concerned than excited about the increased use of AI, and a Marquette University survey last month found that 70 percent of registered voters in Wisconsin felt the costs of data centers outweigh the benefits. One of the main concerns among voters is the impact data centers have on energy prices, given that the U.S. Energy Information Administration found late last year that electricity prices had risen 28 percent since the

SEE AI ON A4



RAGGED WAKED/REUTERS

An Israeli airstrike launches plumes of smoke into the sky Thursday in the southern suburbs of Beirut.

Ex-NFL players decry war video using their hits

BY ROBERT KLEMKO

The video clip is a favorite of Kenny Bell’s friends: The University of Nebraska receiver lays a punishing blind-side block on a Wisconsin defender during the 2012 Big Ten title game. But the clip found new life — and new meaning — last Friday when the White House posted that play, and other devastating pro and college collisions, in a montage that juxtaposed football highlights with footage of U.S. military strikes in Iran.

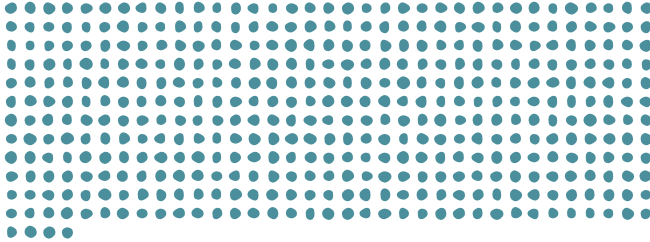
Bell, now retired from pro football at 34, said he was disgusted with the montage set to AC/DC’s “Thunderstruck.”

“For that play to be associated with bombing human beings makes me sick,” Bell told The Washington Post. “I don’t want anything to do with images like that.”

SEE NFL ON A9

Do you support or oppose the U.S. military campaign against Iran?

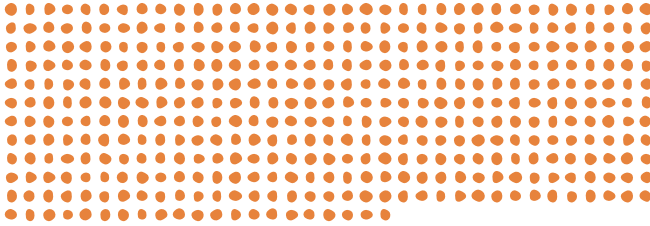
Support 42%



Unsure 17%



Oppose 40%



Satellite photos: Top firms restrict access to Middle East imagery. A14

Shipping law: White House weighs waiver to ease energy costs. A14

Opposition to Iran offensive eases overall

BY SCOTT CLEMENT, ERIC LAU AND ISABELLE GIBSON

What do Americans think about the U.S. war with Iran, and how have their opinions shifted since the conflict began?

A Washington Post poll of 1,005 Americans finds less opposition to the U.S. military actions than when they began, although more people still would prefer that the strikes stop than continue. A steady majority say the Trump administration has not clearly explained the war’s goals, and most say the number of U.S. casualties is unacceptable. Many Americans are still making up their minds on the military campaign or hold a mix of positive and negative views about it.

Participants’ answers have been lightly edited for clarity and style.

SEE IRAN ON A6

Israel widens war at border

LEBANON ON BRINK, APPEALS FOR TRUCE

Hundreds killed in reply to strikes by Hezbollah

BY MOHAMAD EL CHAMAA, SUZAN HAIDAMOUS AND ELLEN FRANCIS

BEIRUT — The U.S.-Israel war against Iran has engulfed Lebanon, pushing the beleaguered country to a new precipice as Israel expands a ferocious bombing campaign and threatens an invasion of south Lebanon in response to strikes by Hezbollah, Tehran’s most powerful proxy.

More than 680 people, at least 98 of them children, have been killed in Lebanon in the past week, while Israeli evacuation orders and strikes have forced 800,000 people to flee, authorities here say.

To stave off a disaster, Lebanon’s government has appealed to U.S. and European leaders to intervene, officials said, even offering to engage in once-taboo talks with Israel. Israel rejected the proposal, according to two people familiar with the matter who, like others, spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive diplomacy.

Lebanese officials, in a diplomatic scramble from Beirut to Paris to Washington, have called for a ceasefire, support for the Lebanese army to seize Hezbollah’s arsenal, and eventual direct peace talks with Israel “under American sponsorship,” according to an adviser to President Joseph Aoun.

“The president of the republic is desperate and seeking all means to stop the destruction of the country and halt attacks,” the adviser said.

Israeli airstrikes Thursday hit near schools, pubs and government buildings in the capital, Beirut, and pounded Lebanon’s

SEE LEBANON ON A12

DHS choice hired felon who illegally kept guns at work

Employee said Mullin knew his record but let him store the weapons

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF AND MARIA SACCHETTI

President Donald Trump’s new pick to lead the Department of Homeland Security, Sen. Markwayne Mullin (R-Oklahoma), employed a supervisor at his family plumbing business who illegally stored weapons and ammunition in an office safe in 2009, according to federal court records.

The employee, Timothy L. Saylor, was previously convicted of felonies, barring him from owning firearms. He said Mullin knew his criminal history but nonetheless allowed him to store the weapons at Mullin Plumbing in Oklahoma.

“Markwayne knew I was a felon,” Saylor said in an interview with The Washington Post. “Of

course he knew. Because I told him.”

The incident became a controversy during Mullin’s first run for Congress in 2012. At the time, Mullin denied knowing about Saylor’s criminal history, telling the Tulsa World that he did not conduct a background check. Mullin said that was because Saylor had been an existing employee of a business purchased by Mullin Plumbing.

Federal law makes it a crime to knowingly provide a weapon to a felon. Mullin told authorities at the time that he gave Saylor guns “to clean.” Mullin was never charged, according to court records.

Mullin’s background and views have faced fresh scrutiny since last week, when Trump said he was nominating him to succeed Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem at the end of the month. Mullin must be confirmed by his colleagues in the U.S. Senate to run the department, which includes the nation’s largest law enforcement agency,

SEE MULLIN ON A5



BRENDAN SMIALOWSKI/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A weather whipsaw in nation’s capital

A woman near the Supreme Court fends off snow flurries Thursday, after record-high temperatures the day before. What weirdness awaits today? Forecast, B18

IN THE NEWS

Squeezed and cutting back Americans are driving less, skipping meals and putting off big life moves to keep up with health care costs, according to two new Gallup polls. A4

Attack at Michigan synagogue A man is dead after ramming his car into the building and being shot at by security, officials said. A7

THE NATION
Chef René Redzepi resigned from Noma amid abuse allegations by former staff. A2
The exploding demand for weight-loss drugs is changing how Americans buy medicine. A2

THE WORLD
A Ukrainian missile strike in Russia’s Bryansk region inflicted heavy damage on a key plant supplying electronic parts for the Russian war machine, Kyiv officials said. A11

THE ECONOMY
As energy prices become a potent issue, one expert claims these rules would reduce average monthly electric bill by almost a third. A18
With no clear end in sight, the Iran war sent oil prices back to \$100 per barrel, and stocks sank worldwide. A18

STYLE
Pixar movies are often beloved by children. “Hoppers” is the film we need as adults. B1

SPORTS
Super Bowls aren’t won in March, but NFL teams sink billions into free agency to build toward that end. We have winners and losers. B7

THE REGION
D.C. legislators have sued Mayor Muriel E. Bowser for budget documents that she has withheld for years. B11

WEEKEND
The nation’s 250th birthday may be on the Fourth of July, but the salutes to the country are already beginning.

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